

CERT-IN · AI THREAT LANDSCAPE GUIDANCE

CERT-In's 12-Hour Patch Mandate

India's AI-paced patching standard — the tiered schedule, the data behind it, and what your security team should do now.

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On 25 May 2026 CERT-In set an indicative 12-hour expectation for containing or remediating known exploited vulnerabilities (KEVs) on internet-facing and high-value "crown-jewel" systems — a timeline calibrated to the speed at which AI-assisted attacks now weaponise disclosed flaws. It is the first national tiered patch standard explicitly paced to AI exploitation speed.

The tiered remediation schedule

VULNERABILITY + EXPOSURE PROFILE	WINDOW	WHAT QUALIFIES
KEV on internet-exposed / high-value system	12 hours	Already exploited in the wild; internet-facing or crown-jewel asset
Critical, not yet exploited, externally exposed	24 hours	Critical severity with external exposure, no confirmed exploitation
Critical on internal high-value system	3 days	Critical severity, high-value, not directly internet-facing
High-severity, below critical threshold	5 days	High severity flaws outside the critical band

Indicative, not statutory — yet. CERT-In framed these as indicative expectations rather than legally binding obligations. The signal is unambiguous: the regulator is benchmarking patch cadence against AI-speed exploitation. The 12-hour clock is an obligation to **act** — patch or contain — not exclusively to apply a software fix.

Why 12 hours — the exploit window has collapsed

56 days → ~10 hrs

Average CVE-to-exploit window, 2024 vs mid-2026

28.3%

Of CVEs exploited within 24h of disclosure (Mandiant M-Trends 2026)

51% @ \$2.77

Of 2024–25 CVEs auto-reproduced as working exploits, per CVE cost (CVE-Genie research)

AI frameworks that generate working exploits from a CVE description in minutes have changed the economics of weaponisation. Any organisation holding 30-day or even 7-day windows for internet-exposed systems is running a risk posture formulated before the current AI capability environment existed.

When you can't patch in time — the compensating-control path

CERT-In explicitly accepts interim containment where vendor patches don't exist or deployment can't be compressed. A documented measure executed within 12 hours satisfies the intent of the standard:

- ▶ Network isolation of the affected system from non-essential reachability.
- ▶ Access restriction — authenticated users only; tighten firewall and identity policy.
- ▶ WAF rule deployment to virtually patch the exploited path at the edge.
- ▶ Segmentation, JIT access and protocol restriction that neutralise the exposure.

India vs the current US federal posture

CERT-In (India) · May 2026

- ▶ 12 hours for KEVs on internet-facing / crown-jewel systems
- ▶ Tiered by severity × exposure (12h / 24h / 3d / 5d)
- ▶ Explicitly calibrated to AI exploitation speed
- ▶ Compensating controls accepted as interim compliance

CISA KEV (US) · 2026

- ▶ ~14-day average remediation deadlines
- ▶ Moving toward a 14-day default window
- ▶ Three-day KEV standard reportedly under consideration
- ▶ Same AI threat data informing the debate

What to do in the next 30 / 60 / 90 days

- 1 Audit internet-facing assets and map them against CERT-In advisories and the CISA KEV catalog.
- 2 Integrate a near-real-time KEV threat-intelligence feed with alerting tied to the asset inventory.

- 3 Build and test a compensating-control playbook executable inside 12 hours.
- 4 Stand up tested emergency patch-deployment automation for the internet-facing tier.
- 5 Add vulnerability-triggered containment scenarios to incident-response playbooks.
- 6 Run a live-KEV tabletop: CVE lands 09:00 with confirmed exploitation — contained by 21:00?

How Macksofy helps

As a CERT-In empanelled auditor, Macksofy delivers the readiness this guidance demands — continuous VAPT against internet-facing assets, KEV-aligned threat-intelligence integration, compensating-control playbook design, and the emergency-remediation runbooks that make a 12-hour window feasible. Engagements range from a focused exposure-and-readiness assessment to a managed detect-correlate-contain programme.

References

- CERT-In — AI Threat Landscape guidance, 25 May 2026.
- Cloud Security Alliance — research note on CERT-In's 12-hour patch mandate, May 2026.
- Mandiant — M-Trends 2026 (time-to-exploit metrics).
- CVE-Genie / "From CVE Entries to Verifiable Exploits" — arXiv:2509.01835, 2026.
- CISA — Known Exploited Vulnerabilities catalog (remediation deadlines, 2026).

This brief presents Macksofy Technologies' original analysis of publicly reported facts. Source data is drawn from CERT-In's May 2026 guidance and the cited references, including a Cloud Security Alliance research note, which remain the property of their respective authors. Macksofy is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or representing CERT-In or the Cloud Security Alliance. © 2026 Macksofy Technologies Pvt Ltd.

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